Reading music

The staff, both clefs, note lengths, rests and time signatures.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

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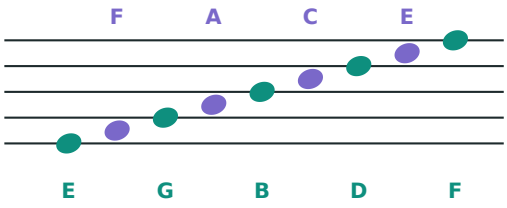
1. The staff and the treble clef

Five lines that show how high a note is.

Five lines

Written music sits on a **staff**: five lines with four spaces between them. Notes are written **on** a line or **in** a space. The higher on the staff, the higher the note.

The curly sign at the start of the staff is the **treble clef** (you'll see it on the next page). It's used for higher notes, usually the right hand. A handy saying for the lines, bottom to top: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**oes **F**ine. The spaces spell **F A C E**.



Lines: Every Good Boy Does Fine
Spaces: F A C E

Figure 3.1 · Five lines

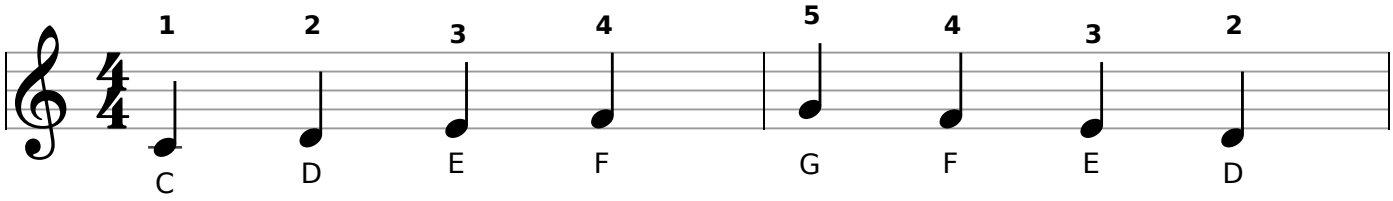
Middle C on the staff

Middle C sits **below** the treble staff on its own short line, called a **ledger line**. Then D hangs just under the staff, E sits on the bottom line, F in the first space, G on the second line.

Notice how each note moves up one notch: line, space, line, space. Steps on the keyboard are steps on the staff.

Practise · Play what you see

Read the notes on the staff and play them. The names are shown underneath to help.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** E The bottom line of the treble staff is E: "Every".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** G The second line is G: "Good". The treble clef curls around this line, which is why it's also called the G clef.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** Middle C A note on its own little line just below the staff is Middle C.

---

2. Reading without names

Train your eyes to read C to G.

Read by shape

Good readers don't name every note. They look at the **direction** and the **distance**: up or down, a step or a skip.

Line to the next space is a step. Line to the next line is a skip. Watch for these shapes as you play.

Practise · Reading drill 1

No names this time. Read from the staff. The keyboard still shows where to go if you get stuck.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Reading drill 2

This time the keyboard won't show you. Read the staff. Tap "Show me" if you need a hint.

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F F is in the first space: the F of "FACE".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** D D hangs just below the bottom line.

3. The bass clef

Low notes, usually for the left hand.

The bass clef

Low notes use the **bass clef**, which looks like a backwards C with two dots (shown on the next page). Its two dots surround the line for **F**, so it's also called the F clef.

Lines, bottom to top: **G**ood **B**oys **D**o **F**ine **A**lways. Spaces: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

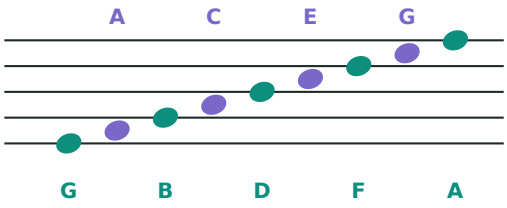


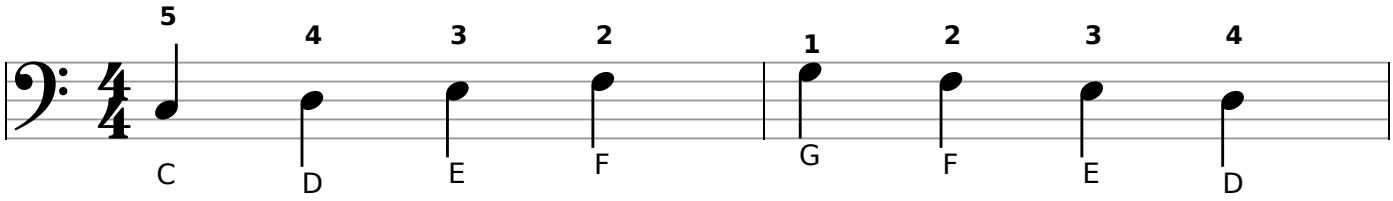
Figure 3.2 · The bass clef

Left hand C position on the staff

The C your left pinky sits on is in the **second space** of the bass staff. From there, D is on the middle line, E in the next space, F on the fourth line and G in the top space.

Practise · Read with your left hand

Left hand in C position. Read the bass staff.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Bass reading drill

No names now. Up or down? Step or skip?

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** C C is the second space of the bass staff: "All Cows".

> **Review**
>
> What is this note?
>
> **Answer:** F F is the fourth line, right between the two dots of the bass clef.

4. The grand staff

Both clefs joined, with Middle C in between.

Two staves together

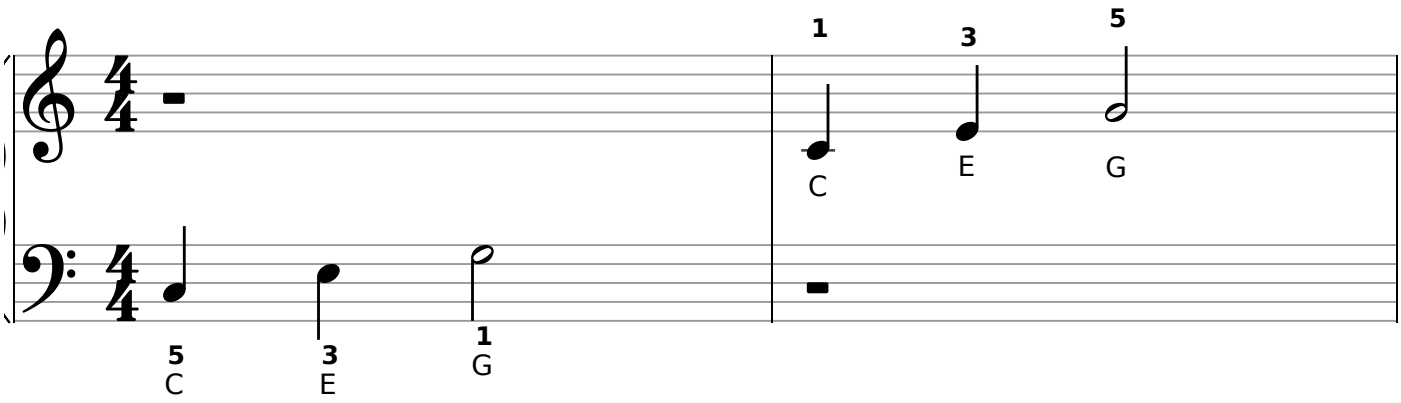
Piano music joins a treble staff and a bass staff with a brace. This is the **grand staff**. The top is usually your right hand, the bottom your left.

Middle C sits right between them. It can be written just below the treble staff or just above the bass staff. Same key, same sound.

> **Review**
>
> On the grand staff, which hand usually reads the bottom staff?
>
> **Answer:** Left hand The bass (bottom) staff is usually for the left hand.

Practise · Taking turns

The hands take turns: left hand first, then right. Read each staff.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

5. Moving your hand to a new position

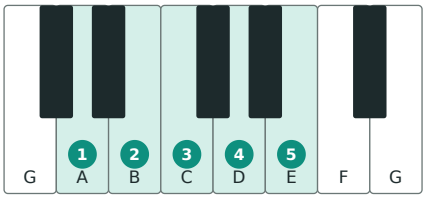
Move your whole hand, then find the next notes without stretching.

Your hand can move

C position is a starting place, not a rule that your thumb must stay on C. When a melody leaves those five keys, you can **release and move your whole hand**. Let your forearm follow, keep your wrist flexible, and settle over the new keys. Do not anchor one finger and stretch the others.

Try this silently: find Middle C with your right thumb. Release, move two white-key steps to the left, and put your thumb on **A below Middle C**. Your fingers now cover **A B C D E**: 1 2 3 4 5. Middle C is under finger 3. Look at your hand while you learn the move.

This is a position shift. Thumb-under for scales is a different movement, taught later. Take this slowly; no stretching or quick jumps are needed.

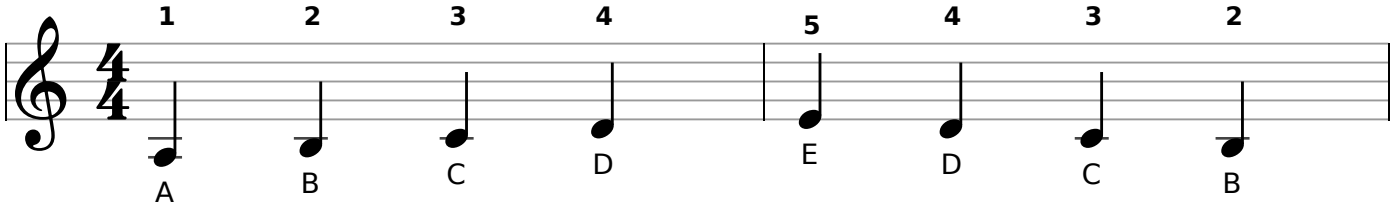


Right hand: A B C D E, fingers 1 2 3 4 5.

Figure 3.3 · Your hand can move

Practise · Find the lower five-note position

Set your right thumb on A below Middle C before starting. Play A B C D E and back. Fingers 1 2 3 4 5, then 4 3 2 1. Keep each finger near its key.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Release, move, and settle

Start with your thumb on Middle C. After the long C, release and move your thumb down to A. Play A B C D E. Then release, return your thumb to Middle C, and play C D E F G C. Pause freely at each move in this exercise. Say the next thumb note before you move.

Practise · Prepare the Doxology phrase

Before playing, settle into A B C D E position: thumb on A below Middle C and finger 3 on Middle C. Play C D E D C A B C using 3 4 5 4 3 1 2 3. Every note is now under one of your five fingers.

Plan the next position

Practise the move silently once more. You will use it in the Doxology later in this chapter. For **“Praise Him above”**, use thumb on A below Middle C and finger 3 on Middle C. Before **“Praise Father, Son”**, release and return to C position: thumb on Middle C and finger 5 on G.

In the whole melody, prepare the A position between lines 2 and 3, and return to C position between lines 3 and 4. At first, stop between phrases, release, look, move, and settle. Once the moves feel comfortable, make the gaps smaller while keeping the written notes their full length.

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6. Counting and bar lines

Measures, time signatures, and Twinkle Twinkle.

Bars and time signatures

Music is divided into small boxes called **bars** (or measures) by vertical **bar lines**.

The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**. The top number tells you how many beats are in each bar. **4/4** means four beats per bar: count "1 2 3 4, 1 2 3 4".

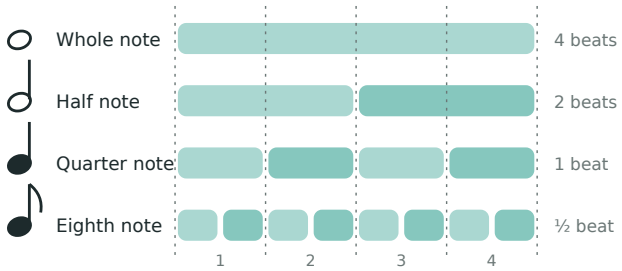


Figure 3.4 · Bars and time signatures

> **Review**
>
> In 4/4 time, how many beats are in each bar?
>
> **Answer:** 4 The top number of the time signature is the number of beats per bar.

> **Review**
>
> How many quarter notes fit into one half note?
>
> **Answer:** 2 A half note is 2 beats, a quarter note is 1 beat.

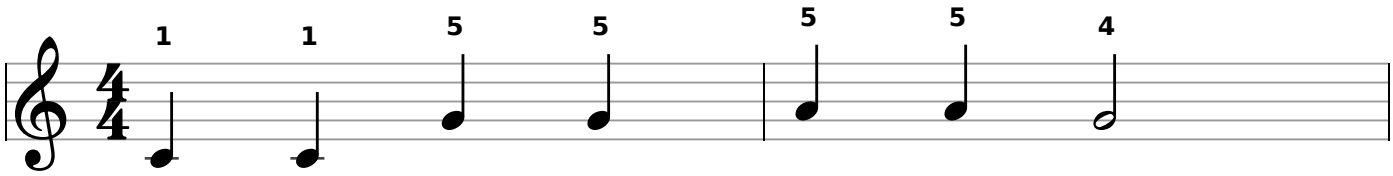
Twinkle, Twinkle

Mozart wrote a famous set of variations on this melody. It needs one note beyond C position: **A**. Begin with your thumb on C and finger 5 on G. After the two Gs, **release and move the whole hand one white key to the right**: thumb on D, finger 5 on A. The following G uses finger 4. Do not keep your thumb anchored on C and stretch.

Return your thumb to C for the final C of the phrase. The middle section uses D position (G with 4, F with 3, E with 2, D with 1); move there before starting it. Pause freely between groups while learning these shifts. The goal is a relaxed move, then a steady phrase.

Practise · Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star

Count 1 2 3 4 in every bar. Hold the half notes for two beats.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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7. Doxology: the whole melody

All four lines, read from the staff and counted in 4.

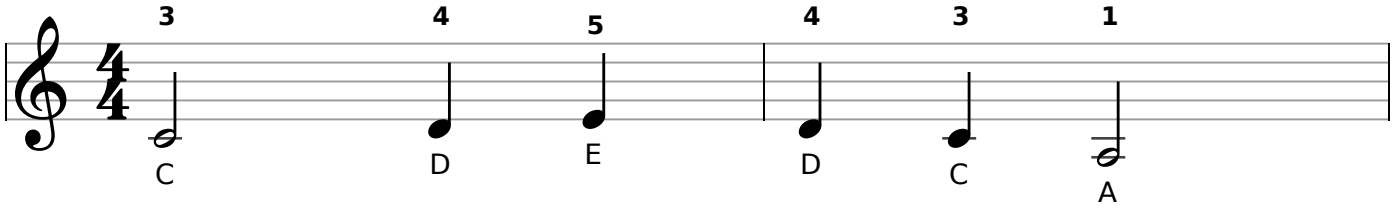
Four lines, twelve bars

Now you can read the staff and count bars, so here is the **whole Doxology melody**. Every line is three bars long, and every line has the same rhythm: a half note, four quarters, then three half notes.

Count it: **1-2 3 4 | 1 2 3-4 | 1-2 3-4**.

Practise · Line 3

"Praise Him above": prepare A B C D E position, thumb on low A and finger 3 on Middle C. Play C D E D C A B C with fingers 3 4 5 4 3 1 2 3. No stretch is needed.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 4

The last line starts high: thumb on Middle C and finger 5 on G. It skips down G, E, C, then climbs back and walks home to C.

Practise · The whole melody

All four lines, reading from the staff. Between lines 2 and 3, release and move to A position (thumb on A below Middle C, finger 3 on C). Return to C position before line 4. Pause between phrases while learning the moves; then join them with a steady count and full-length half notes.

8. When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

Isaac Watts's hymn, counted in 4.

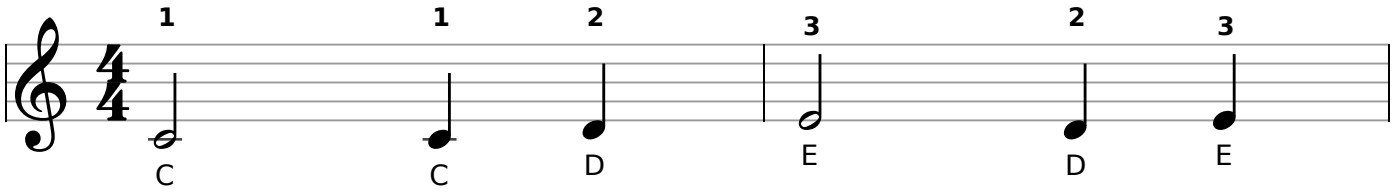
A hymn to count

Isaac Watts wrote these words in 1707, and Lowell Mason's tune **Hamburg** (1824) is how most churches sing them. It's slow and steady: perfect for counting.

Most bars are a half note and two quarters, or a whole note at the end of a line: count **1-2 3 4**, or **1-2-3-4**. Line two dips to the **B** below Middle C: reach your thumb down for it, then come back.

Practise · Lines 1 and 2

Thumb on Middle C. Count out loud: 1-2, 3, 4.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · When I Survey the Wondrous Cross

All four lines. Hold every whole note for its full four beats.

9. Eighth notes: "1 and 2 and"

Two quick notes in one beat.

Half a beat

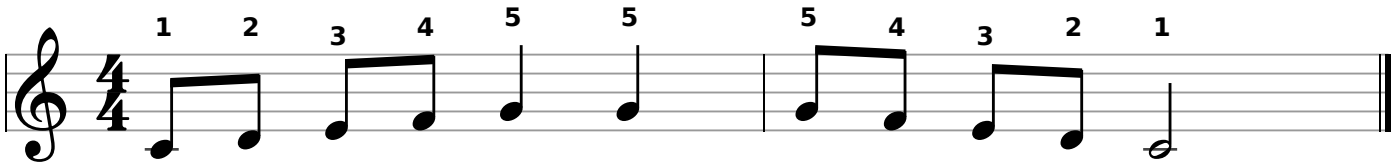
An **eighth note** lasts half a beat, so two of them fit into one beat. On their own they have a little flag. In pairs they're joined by a thick line called a **beam**.

To count them, put the word "and" between the beats: "**1** and **2** and **3** and **4** and". The numbers land on the beat and the "ands" land halfway between.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Which half has the quicker notes?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** The second half The second half has eighth notes: two notes in every beat, so they move twice as fast.

Practise · Running eighths

Count out loud: "1 and 2 and". The eighth notes go up and down the C position.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Hot Cross Buns, with eighths

"One a penny, two a penny" is all eighth notes. Keep them even.

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10. Ties and pickup notes

Holding across a bar line, and songs that start early.

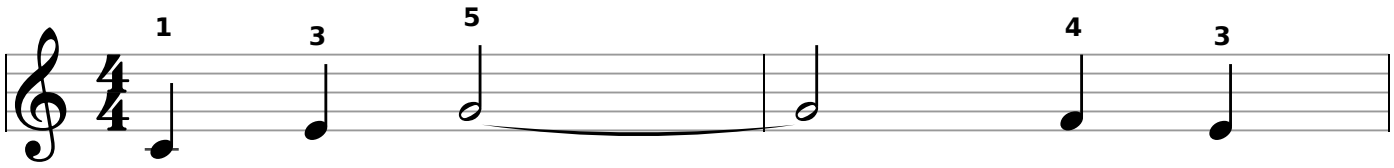
The tie

A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes of the **same pitch**. Play the first note and keep holding it through the second. Don't play it again.

Ties let a note last across a bar line, like the G above: two beats in the first bar plus two more in the next.

Practise · Hold through the tie

Play each tied note once and keep it held while you count. The app moves on by itself.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Pickup notes

Some songs start **before** beat 1. Those first few notes are called a **pickup**, and they sit in a short bar of their own at the very start.

"Happy Birthday" is a perfect example. You sing "Hap-py" first, and the strong beat lands on "**birth**". It's in 3/4 time, so count "3 | **1** 2 3".

Practise · Happy Birthday

Start on the pickup ("Hap-py"), then lean into beat 1 on "birth". Thumb on Middle C.

11. Rests and 3/4 time

Silence counts too, and the waltz feel.

Rests

A **rest** is a written silence. It lasts just as long as the note it matches: a quarter rest is one beat of silence, a half rest is two.

Keep counting through rests! Lift your finger, but keep your hand ready. When the app reaches a rest, it simply moves on.

Three beats: the waltz

In **3/4** time each bar has **three beats**: "**1** 2 3, **1** 2 3". The first beat is a little stronger. This is the rhythm of a waltz.

A **dotted half note** fills a whole bar of 3/4. The dot adds half the note's length: 2 + 1 = 3 beats.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is this in 3 or in 4?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** 3 (waltz) You can hear the pattern repeat every three beats: ONE two three.

Practise · A little waltz

Count "1 2 3" in every bar. Rests are skipped automatically, but count them anyway.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

12. Kum Ba Yah

A spiritual in 3/4, starting with two pickup notes.

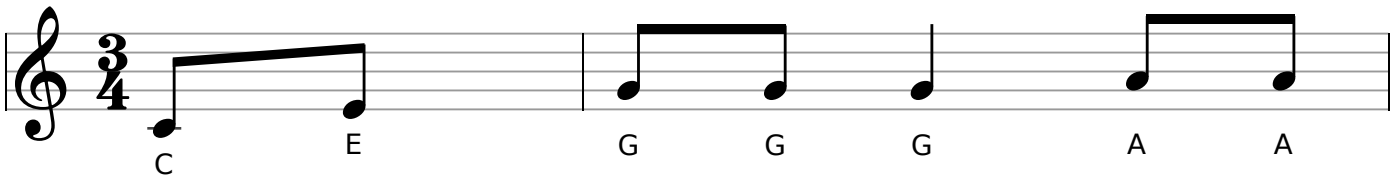
Three beats in a bar

Kum Ba Yah is a spiritual, first written down in the 1920s. It's in **3/4**: count "**1** 2 3" in every bar.

It starts with two **pickup** eighth notes, C and E, on beat 3. Each line climbs to G and holds it, and the last line comes home to C.

Practise · Kum Ba Yah

Count "3 and" for the pickup, then "1 2 3". Smooth and gentle.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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13. Dotted rhythms: Largo

Dvořák's 'Goin' Home' melody.

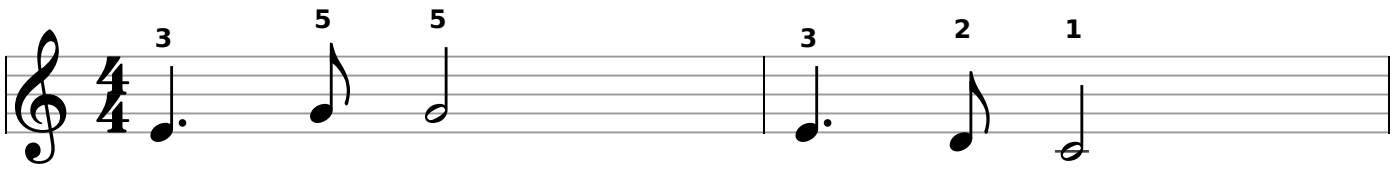
The dotted quarter

A **dotted quarter note** lasts a beat and a half. It's usually followed by a short eighth note to fill the beat: "long… short".

This rhythm opens the slow movement (Largo) of Dvořák's **New World Symphony** (1893). Listen before you play.

Practise · Largo, New World Symphony

Right hand in C position. Play it slowly and sweetly, holding the long notes.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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14. Muss i denn

A German farewell song with dotted quarters.

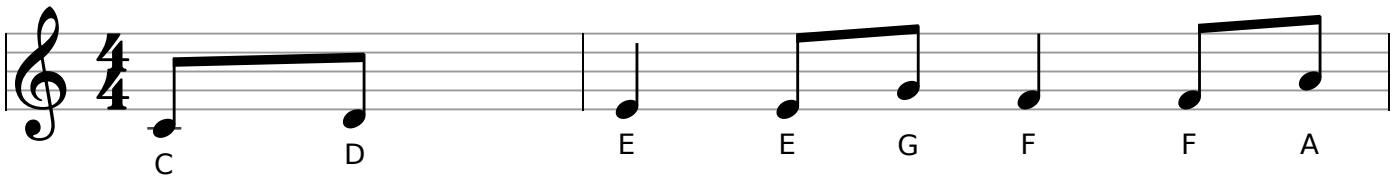
A farewell song

Muss i denn ("Must I, then, leave the little town?") is a German folk song from the 1820s. Elvis Presley sang it in English as "Wooden Heart".

It starts with two pickup eighths, C and D. In the middle section, look for the **dotted quarter notes** you just learned: "**1**-2 and", long then short.

Practise · Muss i denn

Bouncy, at a walking pace. Feel the long-short of each dotted quarter.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

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15. Repeat signs

Two dots that tell you to play it again.

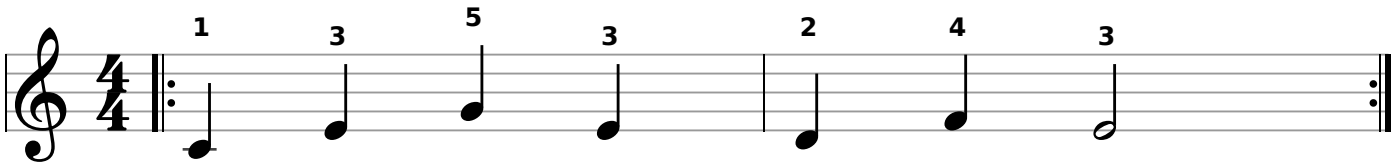
Play it again

A thick bar line with **two dots** is a **repeat sign**. When you reach the dots facing backwards, go back to the matching sign facing forwards (or to the very start, if there isn't one) and play that part again.

Composers use repeats to save paper. Sometimes the second time through has a different ending, marked with brackets numbered **1.** and **2.**: skip the first bracket on the way through again.

Practise · Repeat drill

When you reach the repeat sign, jump back and play those two bars again.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Twinkle, with a repeat

"Up above the world so high, like a diamond in the sky" is the same music twice, so it's written once with repeat signs.

16. Fox, You Stole the Goose

A German children's song in 2/4, with a repeat.

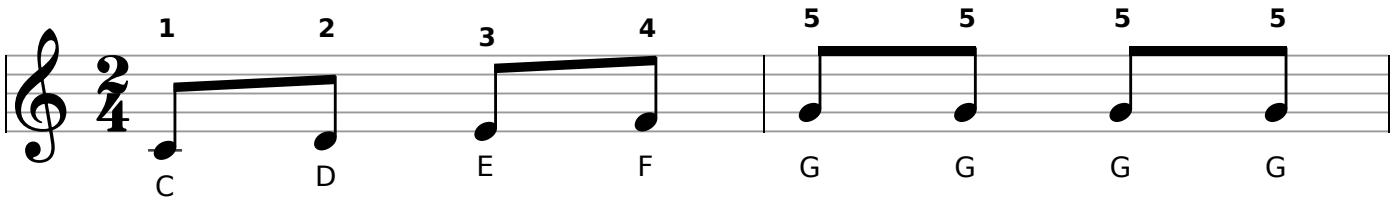
Two beats in a bar

Fuchs, du hast die Gans gestohlen ("Fox, you've stolen the goose, give it back!") is a German children's song. It's in **2/4**: just two beats per bar, mostly running eighth notes.

"Gib sie wieder her" ("give it back") comes twice, so it's written once between **repeat signs**.

Practise · Fox, You Stole the Goose

Run up C D E F G. Play the bars inside the repeat signs twice.



Opening example · 2/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

17. Reading hands together

Ode to Joy from the grand staff.

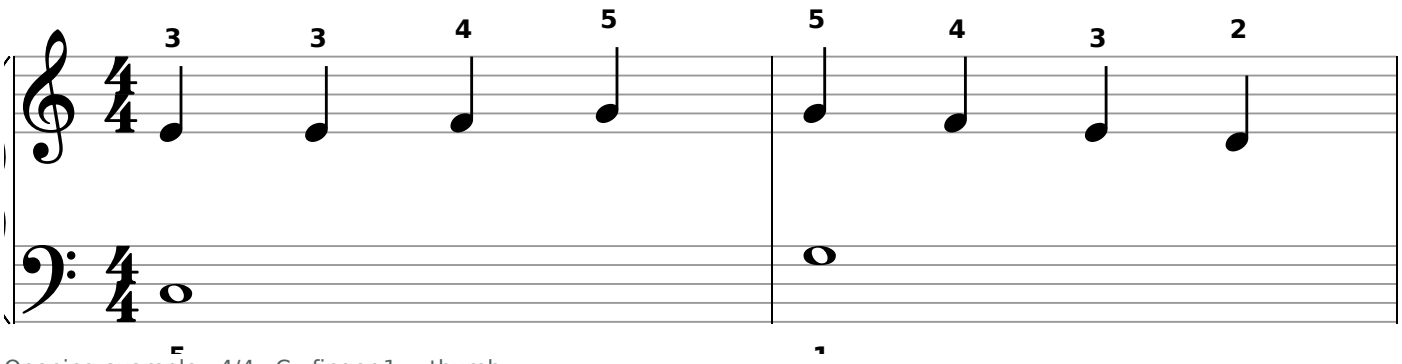
Reading two staves

Reading both staves at once is a skill that grows slowly. A good habit: before you play, look at the **bottom staff** for each bar. The left hand changes less often, so it's easier to plan ahead.

You already know this piece. Now read it from real sheet music.

Practise · Ode to Joy on the grand staff

Read both staves. The app waits for both hands where they play together.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

18. Intervals: 2nds to 5ths

Measuring the distance between two notes.

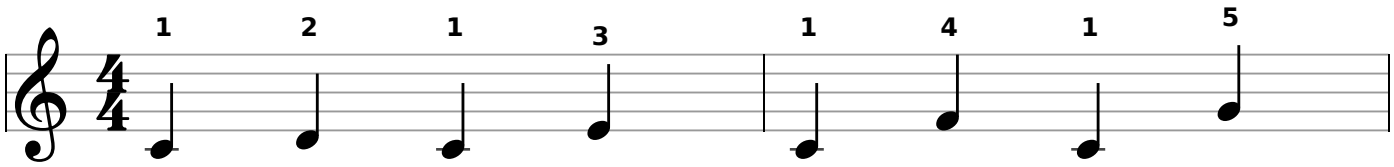
Counting the distance

The distance between two notes is called an **interval**. To name one, count the letters from the first note to the second, **counting both**. C to D is a **2nd** (C, D). C to E is a **3rd** (C, D, E). C to F is a **4th**, and C to G is a **5th**.

On the staff: a 2nd goes line to space, a 3rd goes line to line, and a 5th goes line to line with one line skipped. In C position, the interval matches the gap in finger numbers plus one: thumb to finger 3 is a 3rd.

Practise · Growing intervals

Keep your thumb on C and stretch a little further each time: 2nd, 3rd, 4th, 5th.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

> **Review**
>
> What interval is this?
>
> **Answer:** A 3rd E to G: count E, F, G. Three letters, so it's a 3rd (line to line).

> **Review**
>
> What interval is this?
>
> **Answer:** A 5th D, E, F, G, A: five letters, so it's a 5th.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> Listen. Is this a 2nd or a 5th?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** A 5th A 5th sounds open and wide. A 2nd is right next door and sounds crunchy when played together.

> **Review · ear training**
>
> And this one?
>
> Listen to the example in the app before checking the answer.
>
> **Answer:** A 2nd E and F are neighbours: a 2nd.

19. Amazing Grace

A gentle waltz-time hymn, read from the staff.

Amazing Grace

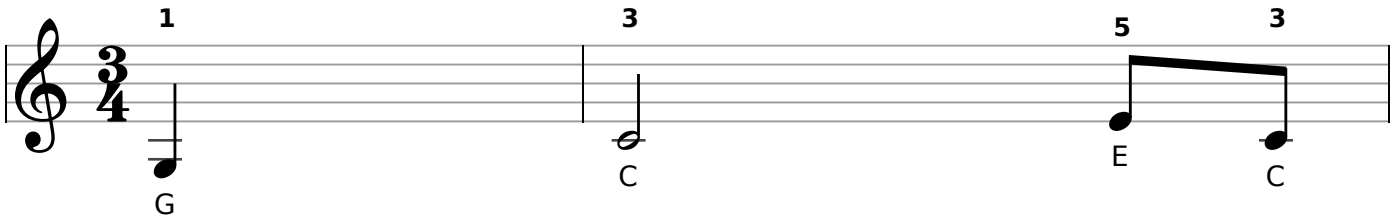
John Newton wrote the words in 1772. The tune everyone knows, **"New Britain"**, was joined to them in 1835.

It's in **3/4** and starts with a **pickup**: a single beat before the first full bar. Count "3" for the pickup, then "**1** 2 3" in every bar.

Hand position: thumb on the **G below Middle C**. In the second line your hand moves up so the thumb sits on Middle C, and then comes back.

Practise · Line 1

Thumb on low G. Read the staff; the little curls are eighth notes.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 2

Thumb moves to Middle C. Hold the high G for three beats.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

Two silent beats, then up high again. Then back to low G for the ending.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole hymn, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

20. Simple Gifts

A Shaker song full of skipping eighth notes, read from the staff.

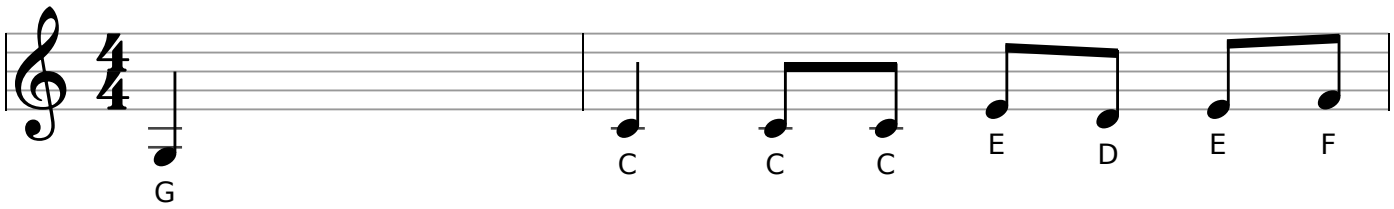
Simple Gifts

Joseph **Brackett**, a Shaker elder in Maine, wrote "Simple Gifts" in 1848. A century later Aaron **Copland** made it famous in his ballet *Appalachian Spring*.

It starts with a one-beat **pickup** on the G below Middle C. After that, look for pairs of **eighth notes**: two notes in the time of one beat. Say "1 and 2 and" as you play them.

Practise · Line 1

"'Tis the gift to be simple, 'tis the gift to be free..."



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Line 2

"'Tis the gift to come down where we ought to be." It ends on Middle C.

Practise · Lines 3 and 4

The second half starts high on G, then dances back down.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole song, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

21. Away in a Manger

A lullaby carol in 3/4 that floats gently downward.

Away in a Manger
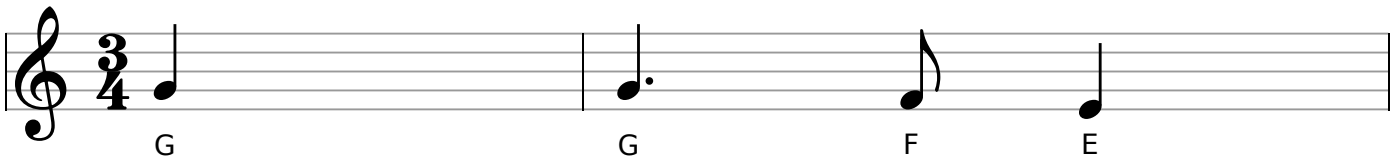
This American tune by James R. **Murray** was published in 1887 and is sung at Christmas all over North America.

It's a lullaby in **3/4**, like Amazing Grace, and starts with a one-beat **pickup**. Each line begins high on G and drifts down, step by step, below Middle C.

Watch for the **dotted quarter** followed by an eighth: a gentle "lo-ong, short".

Practise · First half

"Away in a manger, no crib for a bed…" Let it rock gently, 1 2 3.



Opening example · 3/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Second half

"The stars in the sky…" Same start, then a new ending that settles on Middle C.

Practise · Dress rehearsal

The whole carol, with hints.

Practise · Your recital

This is your performance: no keyboard hints this time. Take a breath, sit tall, and play it from start to finish. Tap "Show me" only if you get stuck.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- ☐ Find treble and bass notes using the staff and landmark notes.
- ☐ Count the note values, rests, ties, and pickups introduced here.
- ☐ Follow repeat signs and read both staves together.
- ☐ Read a short unfamiliar passage before turning on hints.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
